Results Section Peer Review: Instructions for Reviewers and Authors

Foundations of Clinical Research · Level 1: From Clinical Question to Publication

Organisation: Neudata (*#ClearDataClearImpact*)

When: after Session 8, see the timeline (individual homework)

Who reviews whom: your reviewer is assigned at random and announced in Session 7. Everyone reviews one draft and receives one review.

Use with: `Manuscript_Brief.pdf`, the results pack for the author's question, and `Response_to_Reviewers_Template.docx`

1. Timeline

When	Who	What
Session 7 (12 December)	Instructor	Announces who reviews whom, and sends the list by email
23:59, Sunday 20 December 2026 (Vietnam time)	Author	Emails the Results draft directly to the reviewer and to the instructor
Wednesday 30 December 2026	Reviewer	Emails the review report (`Surname_Firstname_Review.docx`) to the author and to the instructor
Saturday 9 January 2027	Author	Emails the revised Results section (tracked changes) and the response letter to the instructor

If your draft has not arrived by the morning of Monday 21 December, email the author and the instructor. Plan about 1.5 hours for the review.

2. How to review (reviewer)

1. Read the draft once without commenting. Write in one sentence what it found.
2. Open the results pack for the author's question and check every number in the text and tables.
3. Answer the Results checklist below (Yes / No, with page or line).
4. Sort your comments into **major** (would change the numbers or the reader's trust) and **minor** (wording, formatting). About 2 to 4 major and 3 to 8 minor.
5. If the author sent optional parts (Methods, Introduction, Discussion, Abstract), add one or two comments on each.

Results checklist

#	Check	Yes / No	Page / line
1	The working title names population, exposure, outcome and design, with "associated"		
2	Participants first: numbers enrolled, analysed and excluded, with reasons		
3	Table 1 summarised in one or two sentences, with numbers. Missing data reported		
4	Outcome numbers per group, with denominators		
5	Main result: crude and adjusted estimates with 95% CI		
6	Other analyses from the pack reported (sensitivity, imputation or subgroup)		
7	Every number agrees with the results pack		
8	Every table and figure from the pack is included, cited in the text and stands alone (title, units, n, abbreviations)		
9	No interpretation and no causal words ("because", "caused", "trend")		
10	AI-use statement present		

3. Tone rules

1. Comment on the text, not the person: "The Results do not report the crude OR", not "You forgot...".
2. Be specific: page, line, the problem and a suggestion.
3. Start with two genuine strengths.
4. Stay within the data. Do not ask for analyses that are not in the pack.
5. Keep it confidential. Do not share the draft and do **not** paste it into an AI tool.

4. What a good review report looks like

A review report helps the author improve the draft. It is more than a list of yes and no answers. Use this structure:

Part	What it contains
Summary	One paragraph: what the draft reports, in your own words, and its two main strengths
Major points	Problems that change the numbers or the reader's trust: wrong numbers, missing results, missing 95% confidence intervals (CI), causal words. Number them M1, M2 and so on
Minor points	Wording, formatting, labels, abbreviations not explained. Number them m1, m2 and so on
Recommendation	Accept as it is, minor revision or major revision, with one sentence on why

Tone. Be polite and specific. Give the line, table or figure for every point. Say what the problem is and suggest a fix. Write about the text, not the author.

Example review (about 250 words)

Invented for teaching. It reviews a Q1 draft and checks every number against the Q1 results pack.

> **Summary.** The draft reports 28-day mortality in 618 adults with sepsis by fluid balance at day 3. Patients with a positive balance died more often, and the association was smaller after adjustment. The participant flow is clear and complete (lines 1 to 4). Table 1 is well laid out and shows the missing data for each variable.
>
> **Major points**
>
> - M1. Line 12 gives the adjusted odds ratio (OR) of 1.62 without its 95% CI. Please add "95% CI 1.02 to 2.59" (pack Table 3).
>
> - M2. Line 14 states that a positive balance "increased the risk of death". FLUID-ICU is a cohort study, so I suggest "was associated with higher 28-day mortality".
>
> - M3. Line 9 reports 136 deaths in the positive-balance group, but Table 2 gives 134 of 373. Please check every number in the text against the tables.
>
> - M4. The heart failure analysis (pack Table 5 and Figure 4) is not reported. The brief asks for all the results in the pack.
>
> **Minor points**
>
> - m1. Lines 9 and 10 give percentages without denominators ("35.9% vs 18.4%"). Please write "134 of 373 (35.9%) vs 45 of 245 (18.4%)".
>
> - m2. The footnote of Table 2 does not explain "RR".
>
> - m3. Line 16 calls the Cox result "borderline significant". I suggest reporting the hazard ratio of 1.46 (95% CI 1.00 to 2.13) without a label.
>
> **Recommendation:** major revision. The draft is clear and well organised, and each change above is quick to make.

5. Review report template

Copy this into `Surname_Firstname_Review.docx`.

Draft reviewed: author _____, Question Q___, working title: _____

Reviewer: _____ **Date:** _____

1. Summary (one paragraph): what the Results show, in your own words, and two genuine strengths.

2. Major points (each with line, table or figure, the problem and a suggestion).

- M1.
- M2.

3. Minor points.

- m1.
- m2.

4. Results checklist: attach the completed table from section 2.

5. Optional parts (if sent): one or two comments on each.

6. Recommendation (tick one, and add one sentence on why): ☐ Accept as it is ☐ Minor revision ☐ Major revision

6. How authors respond (author)

1. Read the review, then wait a day before replying.
2. Use `Response_to_Reviewers_Template.docx`. Thank the reviewer in one sentence.
3. For every comment give: the comment (copied), your reply, and what you changed, with page and line.
4. Make the changes with tracked changes switched on.
5. You may disagree, politely and with reasons from the data.
6. Never answer just "Done".

Example

Reviewer comment	Response	Change in the Results
M1. Only the adjusted OR is given, so readers cannot see how much adjustment changed the estimate.	Thank you. We now report the crude OR next to the adjusted OR.	p. 2, lines 4 to 7, and Table 2

7. Marking

The review you give and your response are criteria 8 and 9 of Manuscript_Rubric.pdf (20 points).